

# Joy to the World

Sitting snugly in the palm of the hand, the joystick is everyone’s favourite gaming device. We evaluated this versatile performer to bring you the best

The Indian market has some of the best joysticks present in the global scenario. A glut of low-priced sticks storm the arena every few months, and then vanish off the shelf at the same speed. The major players are Microsoft and Logitech with awesome technologies and prices to match. Companies such as Saitek, Frontech and Typhoon provide the price-to-performance advantage. We tested 10 joysticks from five different vendors on various parameters.

## Digit Test Process

We tested the gaming devices on our test-bench comprising a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz on an MSI 845E MAX2 BLR motherboard, 256 MB DDR RAM and a 40 GB Seagate ATA IV 7,200-rpm hard drive running Windows XP. Four primary parameters were considered: features, ergonomics, build quality and value for money. Each parameter was assigned a weightage of 25 per cent. The overall scores were then calculated from these.

**Features:** For evaluating the features, we took into account various parameters—a USB interface scored better than a game port interface. Other features that made a difference were force feedback, number of axis, the presence of a hat-switch, a push throttle and the number of programmable buttons.

**Ergonomics:** Comfort is of paramount importance when judging the usability of a joystick. We awarded points for a large palm rest at the base of the stick. Sticks with good comfortable buttons evidently scored more. The grip and thumb recess made for more points.

**Build quality:** The build quality was evaluated on various factors such as quality of the materials used—the ball joint was given prime importance. As far as the button quality was concerned, we considered the tackiness and the play the button offers—lesser the play, better the sturdiness and hence higher the score. For overall finish, we looked for panel gaps and squeaking sounds that are usually present in a bad quality product.



- Joysticks are ideal for playing flight simulator and space games, so if you are a great fan of these don't settle for a game pad.
- Joysticks are available in many flavours, but ideally they should have a hat-switch, a throttle control and at least six programmable buttons.
- Before you buy a joystick, check out the ball joint to ensure its durability. Do this by holding the broom stick and moving it side ways, if the motion is jerky or sticky, don't buy it.
- Before you zero-in on a stick, hold it to see whether your palm and fingers feel comfortable, and your fingers reach the buttons without extending them.
- Always buy a stick with a heavy base, since a light base will skid or trip when the stick is moved vehemently.
- If you are an avid fan of flight simulators, go for a stick that has three axes. This will give you better control over the rudder.

## Frontech JIL-1730 Joystick Action

**Features:** An unresponsive throttle, six programmable buttons and a 4-way hat-switch **Price:** Rs 1,200 **Contact:** Jupiter Infosys India Ltd **Phone:** 022-2001211/2001212 **E-mail:** frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in **Web site:** www.frontechonline.com

The JIL-1730 lacks in quality and feels too light; people with small hands may not be able to reach the head-mounted buttons. The stick does offer a large palm rest for maximum comfort and has four suction cups that hold the table firmly.

The head has two sunken buttons on either side of a centrally placed four-way hat-switch. The buttons are hard and require a firm push to operate. The trigger offers a tactile feel with good response. The joint seriously lacks the punch and feels too slack. A throttle wheel provides enough throw for linear throttle control but could be improved upon. Installation is hassle-free, but the calibration is a bit of a worry since you need to use the trim controls present on the underside of the joystick while calibrating the X and Y axis.

With a price tag of Rs 1,200, it's way too expensive considering that at the same price one can get more features with a better build quality.



| Frontech JIL-1730 Joystick Action |        |  |  |  | B- |
|-----------------------------------|--------|--|--|--|----|
| Features                          | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Build quality                     | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Ergonomics                        | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Value for money                   | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| OVERALL                           | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |

## Frontech JIL-1737 Josh Stick

**Features:** Rumble effects, USB interface, two-axis control, a slider for controlling the rumble effects **Price:** Rs 1,500 **Contact:** Jupiter Infosys India Ltd **Phone:** 022-2001211/2001212 **E-mail:** frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in **Web site:** www.frontechonline.com

The entire body of the Josh stick is in dark violet with a silvery base, making it an absolute stunner. The thumb recess, good amount of thumb rest and large palm rest pad make it very comfortable even during long gaming sessions.

Two buttons are mounted on the head along side the hat-switch and one button is placed under the thumb for quick-action fire. The trigger button is smooth. The base is large with suction cups at the bottom to hold on to any surface tightly. It has a Turbo, Slow, Clear, Select and Start button alongside a slider that can be used to vary the rumble effects.

We experienced problems getting the rumble effects since the drivers could not properly detect the device. This device could do much better with more reliable drivers that can get the maximum out of it. A price tag of Rs 1,500 for a rumble stick with a good design does make it a good option though.



| Frontech JIL-1737 Josh Stick |        |  |  |  | B+ |
|------------------------------|--------|--|--|--|----|
| Features                     | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Build quality                | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Ergonomics                   | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| Value for money              | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |
| OVERALL                      | ▶▶▶▶▶▶ |  |  |  |    |